

Changing a Pad

As most of our service users are over 5 years old, if they wear a nappy, we call them Pads. Pads are a part of everyday life for many people with disabilities or other physiological issues. It is important to be prepared and efficient when changing the pad of a service user (SU) as they may be easily embarrassed by the process.

Remember: Approximately 12% of our clients wear a pad and the majority of that 12% are supported 2:1, so you will usually not be on your own when it comes to changing a pad. If this is the case one of you will usually change the pad while the other worker will engage with the SU, this may be holding their hands, singing songs or action rhymes or giving them a twiddle to play with. Keep their hands busy so the other worker can change them without interruption.

Try your best to preserve the SU's privacy and give them as much control over the process as you can. The following will explain 3 different techniques you can use to change a pad and you need to use the one that the SU is used to.



Look for signs. Watch for indications that they need changing. In case of soiling accidents, it is usually easy to smell and you may have noticed they were standing in an easily discoverable "soiling" position and even heard them farting loud.

- How often this occurs will depend on a number of factors (health of the person, etc.).
- If possible, remind them to change themselves if they are able to do so.

Do a discreet verbal or physical check. With more independent SU, you can ask them if they need help with a pad change. If they are less independent, you may need to do a visual check. Quickly peek inside the back and front of the pad to see if it is wet or soiled.

- They may resist your need to check if they need changing, so be sensitive to their feelings. Respect their privacy and dignity as you check.
- Prepare to change or have them change their pad as soon as possible. Delays in changing a pad can contribute to the development of a urinary tract infections skin irritation, and rashes.



Go to a public restroom and head into an extra-large stall, a disabled stall or a separate family restroom, if one is available. It is important that the space is big enough for the both of you and that it is clean. Sometimes you may find a restroom with an extra-large changing table.

- If you're around other people, simply say, "Excuse us for a moment, we'll be right back," and leave it at that.
- If you have options, choose the bathroom stall with extra handrails and/or shelves (for changing supplies).



Maintain privacy. Always lock the bathroom door behind you. If there are people standing outside of the bathroom area, feel free to ask them to give you some space as well. Likewise, if you are in a public space, use hushed tones when completing the change. Do not complain aloud or you will further frazzle and embarrass the SU.



Set up the supplies. Parents should of given you a bag which should contain the following: pads, wipes, possibly barrier skin cream, a pair of gloves, and hand sanitizer. Unpack these items and place them nearby for the changing process. If the SU is able, you might ask them to assist by holding the wipes or the fresh pad.

- It's easy to forget or run out of a necessary item. Always check the bag you were given to make sure everything is in there that you need, and remember disposable gloves and hand sanitiser are available from the Time office.
- If you're in a public restroom and can't set out the items, leave them in the bag and pull them out as needed. The fewer supplies that are contaminated with germs, the better.

Prepare for the changing position. How you do this depends on how mobile your SU is. Standing would be the easiest, but if your SU is unable to stand up, or has soiled the pad heavily, then you will need to set up the room for a laying down change.

Wash your hands or use hand sanitizer. Many people will also prefer to put on latex gloves at this point. The goal is to prevent the spreading of germs from you to the SU and vice versa.



Change in a standing position. This is generally the best option for SU's as it is the least stressful and usually the quickest. This position also requires very little space, making it a good choice for small restrooms and other cramped areas. Talk to the SU and explain what you are going to do and gently tap each item/body part before starting. Pull down their pants until they are bunched around their ankles.

- Release the pad side-tabs while holding the pad in place. Use your other hand to wipe the area clean, starting at the back. Once it's clean, pull down the pad, wipe the front area clean with a fresh wipe, then dispose of the soiled pad and wipes.
- If the SU needs support standing, they can grab a handrail (if available), use a walker, touch the wall or grip your shoulders for balance.
- If you think the pad is heavily soiled, use caution in this position as it will be easier to get clothing dirty or make a mess in general.



Change in a sitting position. This is a changing option in areas where seating is provided (e.g. family restroom benches) or in situations where the SU can lift themselves up from a seated position (in a wheelchair, for example), but are not fully capable of standing independently. Have them raise up to remove all lower clothing.

- Have them stay seated as you release the pad side tabs. Ask them to lift up, then pull the pad down. Wipe the back area, then the front. Pull out the pad from under them and dispose of it, along with the wipes.
- Be aware that sitting position requires a degree of upper-body control on the part of the SU.



Change in a lying down position. This option can make SU feel very vulnerable and potentially embarrassed because they are padded just like a baby in that position. However, for those SU's with severely limited mobility or in case of soiling accidents, this is the best option - and also some SU's prefer to be changed laying

down because they are used from early childhood to having their pad changed in this position. Starting by helping the SU, to the changing table in a room). Remove their lower clothes completely. Release the pad tapes, pulling it loose, but not off.

- Gently push the SU's knees chest-ward by applying pressure with your forearm behind the knees. Wipe them clean from front to back, placing used wipes in the pad. When done, pull the soiled pad out.
- When removing clothes, look for signs that the pad has leaked. If they got wet or soiled, replace them with clean ones. Put all wet or dirty clothes in a plastic bag.



Be sure the SU's bottom is clean. Regardless of position, use as many wipes as you need to in order to make them completely clean. If possible, have them help with their own cleaning needs.

- When you are done with cleaning, place the soiled wipes within the soiled pad and fold it up for disposal.
- Make sure to wipe the SU from front to back. This prevents the spread of fecal bacteria and is especially important when changing females and transgender boys.

Put on the new pad and clothing. Grab and unfold the fresh pad and pull it up between their legs, securing it at both sides by fastening the tapes. Make sure that

it's form-fitting without any gaps around the legs or waist, and that it doesn't impede movement. When you're done, put their lower garments back on.

- In the standing position, you'll need to use one hand to hold the pad in place and another to secure the tabs.
- In the sitting position, you will need to have the SU raise up in order to place the fresh pad between their legs and secure it.
- In the laying down position, you will want to keep their knees bent as you place the pad, releasing them after it is in place, then you secure the tabs.



Dispose of anything soiled. Place the soiled pad in the trash or in a nappy bin. Dispose of any wipes that may have fallen on the floor or elsewhere during the process. Look over the area to make sure that it appears the same as it did when you arrived.



Wash your hands again. When you are finished it is even more important to wash your hands or use hand sanitizer, even if you were wearing gloves. It is also a good idea to ask the SU to wash their hands as well.



Pack up your supplies. Make sure that you packed everything back up into the bag. It is very easy to forget wipes, for example, in a rush to get out of the restroom. Ask the SU to help you look around by saying, “Do you see anything I’ve missed-are we good to go?”